

When to learn chess openings

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

Learn opening principles as soon as you can play legal games. Add a small repertoire once you regularly reach playable positions and can explain basic development. Deep memorization becomes useful when recurring positions in your own games demand precise answers; it need not wait for a particular rating.

WORKED EXAMPLE

After repeatedly meeting 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6, choose one sensible setup and study its central pawn plan. If you lose mainly to hanging pieces on move twelve, tactical checking will usually help more than memorizing another twenty moves.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What should trigger your next opening study session?

ANSWER AND REASONING

A recurring practical question from a game: where a piece belongs, which pawn break works, or why an early tactic failed. Learn the answer and a short supporting line, then test it in play.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Start with principles; deepen theory in response to real positions.